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*PAUSAL PHENOMENA AND THE BIBLICAL TRADITION
IN TEXTS WITH PALESTINIAN POINTING*

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PAUSAL PHENOMENA AND THE BIBLICAL TRADITION IN TEXTS WITH PALESTINIAN POINTING

Among Professor Díez-Macho's many contributions to the study of the biblical text, his extensive and valuable work on fragments with Palestinian pointing occupies a significant place. Many of these fragments reflect a pronunciation of Hebrew quite different from that indicated by the standard Tiberian pointing, and thus provide linguistic information of great interest. Their significance for the history of the biblical tradition remains, however, uncertain. This problem is approached in this article by way of their use of what may be called "pausal phenomena". These features: pausal forms, *nesiga*, and conjunctive *waw* pointed with *qames*, seem to result, in the Tiberian text, from the effect of suprasegmental contours delimiting units of speech¹. The position in which these phenomena occur is not predictable from the letters of the text. There is no evidence that they were ever considered significant for the interpretation of the passage in which they occur. Consequently it must be assumed that independent reading traditions would show considerable differences in the marking of such features.

Pausal Forms

The majority of pausal forms occur with *silluq* and *atnah*. These accents are rarely marked in Palestinian MSS. It is clear, then, that accent signs could not have been used as the standard method of marking pausal forms in these texts. In fact, the use of accent signs for this purpose is rarely necessary. Although some 20% of Tiberian pausal forms differ from the corresponding contextual form in stress position, this is the sole difference only in אָנִי and the few cases in which, in "minor pause", there is a change in stress position but not in vowel quality, as in אָתָּה and perfect forms with *waw* consecutive. In all other cases pausal and contextual forms differ in vowel quality, at least in the Tiberian tradition. Consequently the Palestinian accent signs are not considered in the discussion of pausal forms.

¹ For this point of view, see Revell, 1980 (especially p. 176), 1981 (especially p. 92-93), and 1983. (For the works cited, see p. 244).

Most pausal forms differ in vowel pattern from contextual only in the vowel of the syllable stressed in pause. This vowel, historically short, appears in its long reflex in the pausal form, in its short reflex in the contextual. The differences can be categorized, in order of frequency in the material studied, as follows:

1) Pausal *qames*, contextual *patah*, as יְקַדֵּשׁ, יִקְדָּשׁ and many other forms.

2) Pausal full vowel (*holem*, *qames*, *šere*, or *segol*) contextual *shewa*, as in the 2ms suffix, וְרַעַךְ, וְרַעַךְ; לָךְ, לָךְ also verb forms with vocalic affix, as יִסְפְּרוּ, יִסְפְּרוּ and a few other forms.

3) Pausal and contextual forms show different full vowels. The most common case is the segolate noun, as זָרַע, זָרַע. Occasional others occur, as אָחַת, אָחַת; יָגֵלַח, יָגֵלַח.

Equivalent contrasts are not always clearly marked in Palestinian texts. All Palestinian biblical MSS show two "a" signs. In members of classes 1, 2 and 6, these correspond in use to Tiberian *qames* <a>, and *patah* <a'>². In members of classes 3 and 7, they do not, being used more or less as free variants. Cases in which the Tiberian pausal form is distinguished by *qames* as opposed to *patah* are not included in the figures for MSS from classes 3 and 7 in the computation below.

In a number of MSS a vertical and a horizontal stroke are used to mark not only the vowel as <a> and <a'>, but also the accents *zaqef* and *revia*. In these MSS, and in Palestinian MSS generally, the marking of accents is consistent; the marking of vowels is not. Consequently, where either identification is possible, these signs have been considered as marking the accent, not the vowel.

In Palestinian MSS, a full vowel sign is used (if any is), where the Tiberian pointing uses *shewa*, since the Palestinian pointing never developed an equivalent to the Tiberian *shewa* sign³. For general purposes, the sign usually used is <e>; <a'> is the next most common. In some cases, then, one of these signs could represent either a full vowel (*šere*, *segol*, or *qames*) characteristic of a pausal form, or *shewa*, characteristic of a contextual form. The general practice of the fragments, however, is to mark the full vowel of

² The Palestinian vowel signs referred to here are represented as <a>¹, <a'> —, <e> :, <e> :.

The MSS are divided into classes, according to the way they use those signs, as described in Revell 1970. The individual MSS are referred to by the numbers assigned in Revell 1977, as listed on p. 243 below.

³ But it does reflect vowels of *shewa* quality. (Revell 1970a, p. 83-93), and in some manuscripts, as P209, one sign may be used only to represent *shewa* vowels.

a pausal form, but not the *shewa* vowel of a contextual form⁴. Consequently a vowel sign in this situation is taken as marking a pausal form.

In other cases the Palestinian vowel signs clearly distinguish pausal forms from contextual. Following the method of interpretation just described, where L has a pausal form, the Palestinian form is pausal, 375 cases; contextual, 7 cases; not marked, 238 cases⁵. The Palestinian sign used where the vovelling is interpreted as contextual is as follows:

Class 1	Is 10:14 L	אִסְפָּחִי	P206 <a'>
Class 2	1 Chron 2:30 L	וּאִפְּיִם	P308 <a'>
	1 Chron 5:21 L	אִלְפִּים	P308 <a'>
Class 6	Jer 2:3 L	יִאֲשֹׁמוּ	P208 <a'>
Class 7	Jos 15:29 L	וְעֵצִים	P203 <e>
	Jos 19:3 L	וְעֵצִים	P203 <e>
	Ezra 3:3 L	וּלְעֵרֶב	P307 <e>

Pausal forms most commonly stand at the ends of clauses, so that this is the most likely place to find variant pausal forms. Where L shows a contextual form at the end of a clause, the Palestinian form is contextual, 86 cases; pausal, 2 cases; not marked, 122 cases⁶. The cases of pausal vovelling are:

Class 2	1 Chron 4:15 L	וּקְנִי	P308 <a>
Class 3	Ps 35:20 L	אֶרְץ	P310 <a'> ⁷ .

⁴ As with the vovelling of the 2ms suffix in P206, described in Revell, 1977, p. 65.

⁵ About half the cases where the form is not marked occur in the brachygraphic MSS of class 1, in which many words, particularly those with *atnah* or *sillug*, are not represented. See Revell 1977, p. 67. Figures for pausal forms not marked in P211 and P301 are not given, as vowel signs are only occasionally used in those MSS. They mark 18 pausal forms as L, with no variants.

⁶ Figures for P211 and P301 are not included under "not marked". One contextual form is marked, as L, in P301.

⁷ This vowel is not marked in Allony and Díez-Macho 1958, nor in Murtonen 1958 (MS c), nor referred to in Revell 1970, p. 85. It is nevertheless, perfectly clear in the fragment. Since <a> is restricted to final open syllables in this MS, and <e> or <e'> is regularly used where L has segol, there is no doubt that this is a pausal form.

Nesiga

Nesiga refers to the retraction of the word-stress in a word joined by a conjunctive accent to a word stressed on its first syllable. No consistent vowel changes accompany this phenomenon. Consequently *nesiga* can only be shown where the stress position of words with conjunctive accents is marked. In Palestinian texts, this can be done in two ways⁸.

a) In MSS from class 1, and in P308 (class 2) and P208 (class 6), some signs for conjunctives are regularly marked on the stress syllable⁹.

b) P102, 103, 206 (class 1) and P308 (class 2), are written in forms of brachygraphy in which the abbreviated form of the word regularly includes the letter representing the first consonant of the stress syllable¹⁰. Consequently in these MSS, where a word is represented by one letter (other than the last) this can be taken as marking the stress syllable.

In P206, from which the bulk of the evidence comes, a word which shows *nesiga* in L can be treated as follows:

1) Represented by one or more letters marked with an accent sign indicating stress position.

2) Represented by one letter only, with stress position not marked by an accent sign.

⁸ In Dotan 1983, p. 145, Kahle's view that stress position is not marked in texts with Palestinian pointing is maintained. The only argument offered is that in the Palestinian pointing the position of the accent sign on the word is used to distinguish the nature of the accent, not the position of the word stress. In the Tiberian system, several disjunctives are marked by the same sign as a conjunctive, but distinguished by its position on the word, and the same is true for the vowels *holem* and *hireq*. The argument is valueless. The material used here is included among the suggestions in Revell 1977 dismissed by Dotan as difficult to accept (note 7 there). This may be an adequate reaction to some of those suggestions, but to extend it to these particular ones requires an unreasonable willingness to accept a high level of agreement as the result of meaningless coincidence.

⁹ The placing of accent signs in Palestinian fragments is described in Revell 1977, p. 167f. In the MSS concerned they are marked on the same syllable as in L in 80% of the cases or more, save in P208 and P309, where this is true of conjunctive, but not of disjunctive accents. Other MSS use a sign for *telisha qetanna* which could mark stress position, but this is not considered here, as the Tiberian sign is postpositive (although occasionally repeated in L to mark the stress position).

¹⁰ In P308, this is not true where the accent sign is postpositive. See Revell 1969, p. 68.

3) Represented by more than one letter, with stress position not marked by an accent sign.

4) Not represented ¹¹.

Stress position is considered to be marked in 1) and 2), but not in 3) and 4). Where the phonological situation is suitable for *nesiga*, P206 shows the following:

L shows <i>nesiga</i>			L does not show <i>nesiga</i>	
P206 shows stress as L	other		as L	other
1)	26	3	23	1
2)	10	2	1	2
3)		2		3
4)		9		8

Nesiga is not shown where L shows it under 1) in Is 8:21, 54:6, Ez 33:4 (cf. 33:6), under 2) Ez 32:25, 34:14. It is shown where L does not show it under 1) in Is 57:15, under 2) in Is 58:12, 59:8 ¹². Other MSS agree with L in showing *nesiga* in eight cases, with four more uncertain, and agree in not showing *nesiga* in three cases, with three more uncertain. There are no certain variants. Thus, overall, out of 79 cases in which the information permits a valid comparison, the Palestinian fragments agree with L in 71, and conflict in eight, or 11%, a moderate level of variation ¹³.

Conjunctive "waw" with "qames"

Where L shows this phenomenon, Palestinian MSS show ⟨a⟩ in 57 cases, ⟨a'⟩ in three cases, and no vowel in thirteen ¹⁴. The cases of ⟨a'⟩ occur in P203 (class 7) Jos 15:29, 42, 19:3, and could be taken simply as instances of the interchangeability of ⟨a⟩ and ⟨a'⟩ characteristic of MSS of classes 3 and 7. However ⟨a⟩ is used in this situation in 17 cases in MSS from these classes (five of them in P203), and ⟨a'⟩ is commonly used in P203 where L has *shewa*,

¹¹ Words bearing conjunctive accents are often not represented in P206. See Revell 1977, p. 69ff.

¹² In Is 47:2 and 59:4 variant accentuation precludes *nesiga*.

¹³ A, B, C, and L, the MSS associated with the ben Asher family, show negligible variation in the marking of *nesiga*. Others vary more, with the highest level noted (about 20%) found in P (in which the conjunctive accents are not standard Tiberian, as shown by the servi of *zaqef*).

¹⁴ This count excludes P301, in which the vowel of the conjunction is never marked, P310, in which ⟨a⟩ is restricted to final open syllables, and also the cases in P211 in which the vowel is not marked, on account of the sparse use of vowel signs in the MS.

so it is quite possible that <a'> represents a *shewa* vowel in these three cases, indicating a variant use of the ordinary form of the conjunction. There are no cases in which a Palestinian MS appears to reflect the *qameṣ* form of the conjunction where L has *shewa*.

Interpretation

It is quite clear from this survey that, where the writing system is capable of marking a distinction parallel to that by which the features studied here are distinguished in L, this distinction is generally marked in Palestinian MSS in agreement with L. Since Palestinian fragments typically do not mark all vowel and accent signs, the fact that these pausal phenomena are quite often not marked can only be taken as showing that they were considered as no more important than other features of the tradition. Cases of disagreement with L are few and unsystematic. They do not suggest a tradition different in origin from that of L any more than does the similar level of variation found in many MSS with standard Tiberian pointing. The necessary conclusion is, then, that, where distinctions parallel to those of L could be marked, the Palestinian fragments reflect a form of the tradition represented in L¹⁵.

The fact that, in some cases, the relevant distinctions could not be marked by the Palestinian pointing system needs more careful consideration. This fact does not, of course, necessarily imply that the distinctions were not made. Many writing systems, the Tiberian pointing among them, fail to mark all the distinctions recognized in the pronunciation represented. The case of the failure to distinguish two "a" vowels must be decided on the basis of our knowledge of the history of the Hebrew vowel system. It is generally agreed that, of the seven (full) vowels recognized in the standard biblical tradition, *segol* was the last to develop, and was unique to the Tiberian tradition. Ben Hayyim, who accepts this view, even argues that *segol*, which is, in many cases, a reflex of original short "a", was not phonemically distinct from *pataḥ*¹⁶.

¹⁵ The situation is the same in "Palestinian Related" MSS (the pointing classes 13 and 14 of Revell 1977, p. 6), save that their use of the *shewa* sign renders unequivocal the marking of contextual forms and the conjunction where *shewa* is characteristic.

¹⁶ Ben Hayyim 1978, p. 101. This view could only be justified in the context of a complete description of the phonemic inventory represented by the Tiberian pointing, which is unattainable, since that pointing is not a phonemic transcription. On the graphic level, of course, minimal pairs distinguished by *segol* and *pataḥ* can be found, as *גָּלָה* (*gal*) and *חִפָּה* (*hifil*). Ben Hayyim's note on this pair clearly does not regard *segol* and *pataḥ* as representing allophones of the same phoneme.

It would be logical to conclude from this argument that the final development of *segol* involved the differentiation of those reflexes of original short *a* represented by Tiberian *segol* from those represented by *pataḥ*. If so, any system in which the vowels of the one group are marked by "e" signs, and those of the other by "a" signs, (as is true in the Palestinian pointing) must reflect a corresponding development, and so must represent a language tradition which has passed through the earlier stage at which *qameṣ* developed. However it is possible that the historical development followed other lines, so that the decision must rest on a smaller body of evidence. In a small group of cases, the use of *qameṣ* following a *guttural* induces *segol* rather than *pataḥ* as the reflex of original short *a*, as in the pausal form אָתָּה (cf. אֵתָּה). Consequently any system in which these reflexes of original short *a* are marked by a sign corresponding elsewhere to Tiberian *segol* or *sere*, and not by one corresponding to *pataḥ* or *qameṣ*, must represent a language tradition in which a distinction corresponding to that between Tiberian *qameṣ* and *pataḥ* had been developed. Such vowels are regularly marked with an "e" sign in biblical manuscripts with Palestinian or related pointing, as אָתָּה P205, Jud 9:5, אָתָּךְ P305, Dan 10:31, 12:5, and the article in P207, Hos 10:8; P307, Ezra 3:5,7. It is, then, a necessary conclusion that a vowel corresponding to Tiberian *qameṣ* had been developed in the tradition represented by these manuscripts.

If this is so, it is quite true to say that some Palestinian fragments represent forms of the biblical tradition in which this vowel distinction, made in the Tiberian tradition, is obscured or lost. This loss is no doubt due to the influence of a "Sefardi" pronunciation, in which this distinction was not made, as argued by ben Ḥayyim¹⁷. However it is clear that the Palestinian fragments represent a form of the standard tradition which is, in some cases, "Sefardicized", and not, as has often been claimed, a non-Tiberian tradition which has been "Tiberianized". Consequently, where pausal phenomena were marked by distinctions paralleled in this "Sefardi" linguistic environment, they are marked in Palestinian fragments with little variation from L. Where there was no parallel distinction in the linguistic environment, the distinction was partly

¹⁷ It is not, however, clear that this distinction had never been developed. An "e" sign is also used in the Palestinian vocalization of *piyyuṭim* where *qameṣ* following a *guttural* induces Tiberian *segol* as a reflex of original short *a*, see Murtonen 1958, p. 37 (the article), 59 (אָתָּה). The vocalization of *piyyuṭim* is presumably the closest one can get to a representation of the "Sefardi" pronunciation in question, but extensive study would be required to show whether or not it was influenced by the biblical tradition in this or other features.

or wholly lost in some forms of the biblical tradition. The use of the two "a" signs in MSS of classes 3 and 7 (which reflect these forms), is to be interpreted, both generally and in the specific case of the pausal phenomena, as reflecting the influence, on a form of the standard tradition, of a linguistic environment in which a corresponding distinction was not made. This has caused the confusion and hypercorrection typical where traditional spelling is not well learned, and has led, in some cases, to the loss of the distinction corresponding to that marked by Tiberian *pataḥ* and *qameṣ*¹⁸.

It is possible that the failure to mark *nesiga* in most MSS is simply the product of the fact that signs for individual conjunctive accents were not used. The small amount of evidence available suggests that *nesiga* would have occurred generally as in L. It is probable that the linguistic environment would encourage non-final stressing¹⁹, and so affect the cases in which L does not show *nesiga*, rather than those in which it does. However information on stress position is too scanty to allow any firm conclusion.

Conclusion

A study of these pausal phenomena in Palestinian MSS shows, then, very much what would be shown by a study of Tiberian MSS: a variety of forms — some considerably vulgarized — of the tradition which appears in its purest form in the Codices associated with the ben Asher family. Such vulgarization is of interest for the earlier history of the language, but is irrelevant to the earlier history of the biblical tradition. Nevertheless this particular study does have the value of showing that these pausal phenomena were firmly fixed in the common biblical tradition before the vulgarization, or the development of the different systems of vowel and accent signs, had occurred.

¹⁸ The consistent use of <a> where L has *qameṣ* on conjunctive *waw*, and also to represent the final vowel of the 2ms pronominal suffix (Tiberian ך), as noted in Revell, 1970a, p. 57, probably reflects the fact that both forms were confined to the biblical tradition. The use of <a> may, therefore, represent a learned spelling not influenced by spoken forms.

¹⁹ See Revell 1977, p. 215-6.

LIST OF MSS USED IN THIS STUDY
(Where possible, a published fragment is cited)

- Class 1 P102 Kahle, 1930, MS M
P103 Dietrich, 1968, MS Cb1
P202 unpublished
P206 Kahle, 1930, MS M
P309 Diez-Macho, 1967
- Class 2 P211 Dietrich, 1968, Ob2/Cb3
P303 Diez-Macho, 1959
P308 Dietrich, 1968, MS Cb9
- Class 6 P201 unpublished
P208 Kahle, 1930, MS K
- Class 3 P205 Diez-Macho, 1963
P209 Kahle, 1930, MS H
P301 Allony and Diez-Macho, 1958
P302 Kahle, 1930, MS L
P305 Kahle, 1930, MS J
P310 The second hand in P301
- Class 7 P203 Dietrich, 1968, MS Ob1
P207 Yeivin, 1963
P307 Dietrich, 1968, MS Cb2
- L The Leningrad Manuscript
P Codex Babylonicus Petropolitanus.

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